aviation. Designed as a radio-controlled target drone for gunnery training, it was the first fully operational and mass-produced unmanned aerial vehicle (UAV) used by both the Royal Navy and the Royal Air Force (RAF). Its introduction marked the transition from experimental UAV concepts to practical, large-scale military application, demonstrating the effectiveness of drones as reusable aerial targets.

Technically, the Queen Bee was based on the De Havilland DH.82 Tiger Moth, a two-seat biplane widely used as a pilot trainer. The aircraft was modified by fitting a radio control system that allowed ground operators to manage the aircraft's engine power, flight direction, and altitude remotely. A backup cockpit was retained, enabling a pilot to manually take control when needed, making it versatile for both manned and unmanned operation. The drone could take off, perform aerial maneuvers, and land under remote control a remarkable achievement for its time (Dancey, 2014).

The Queen Bee was primarily used for anti-aircraft gunnery practice, allowing military personnel to train with realistic moving targets without endangering pilots. Hundreds of these drones were produced between 1935 and 1943, operating from coastal bases and aircraft carriers across Britain. Their reliability, cost-effectiveness, and operational success made them a standard tool in military training programs throughout the pre-war and World War II periods.

The significance of the Queen Bee extends beyond its military value it is historically recognized as the origin of the term "drone." The aircraft's buzzing engine sound, reminiscent of a male bee, led Royal Navy personnel to nickname it "Queen Bee." This term was later adopted generically to describe all pilotless aerial vehicles.

The Queen Bee (1935) was not only the first operational and mass-produced UAV but also a defining milestone in drone technology. It proved